SLEIGHT OF HAND (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Sleight of Hand is a **Dexterity** skill. It is used to **pick a lock** or **disarm a trap** with Thieves' Tools, to **pick pockets**, to **conceal an object** on yourself, or to **escape manacles**. The DM asks for a roll when the outcome is **uncertain** and **interesting**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. A Sleight of Hand check is an **ability check**: d20 + Dexterity modifier (+ Proficiency Bonus if proficient).
2. Picking a padlock or manacles: **DC 15**, with Thieves' Tools.
3. Escaping manacles: **DC 20**, at the cost of an action.
4. Disarming a trap: **DC 15**, with Thieves' Tools (Traps sheet).
5. Being proficient in both the tool and the skill gives **Advantage**. The Thief can act as a **Bonus Action** (Fast Hands).

⚠ Using another ability:

- The ability of a check is **decided by the situation**: the DM may pair Sleight of Hand with **Intelligence** (puzzle, logic trap), **Charisma** (misdirection), or **Wisdom** (feeling a mechanism). Table rule
- The **Proficiency Bonus** applies when the skill **fits** and you are proficient.
- See the **Use cases** page.

⚠ Change from 2014

The **DCs appear in the equipment** (padlock, manacles) and in the Thieves' Tools description. Being proficient in both the tool and the skill gives **Advantage**.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

No official DC for **picking pockets**, and nothing on the noise or time of a failed pick. Fix: the **DM announces** the DC, the time, and the consequence of failure **before** the roll.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the **click of the pins**, the trembling fingers, the purse changing hands in a heartbeat.

Step 1 – Decide whether a roll is needed:

A roll happens only if the maneuver is **delicate** and the outcome **uncertain**: a complex lock, a trap, a watchful target. A simple latch needs no roll.

Step 2 – Choose the tool:

Picking or disarming requires **Thieves' Tools**. To pick pockets or conceal an object, no tool.

Step 3 – Set the DC:

The task	DC
Pick a padlock or manacles (Thieves' Tools)	15
Disarm a trap (Thieves' Tools)	15
Escape manacles (action)	20
Pick pockets, conceal an object	set by the DM

Step 4 – Make the roll:

d20 + Dexterity modifier + **Proficiency Bonus** if you are proficient in Sleight of Hand. If you are also proficient with Thieves' Tools, you have **Advantage**.

Example: Brann (Dexterity +3, Proficiency +2, tools proficient) picks a padlock (DC 15). With Advantage, he rolls 7 and 12, keeps 12: 12 + 3 + 2 = 17, success.

Step 5 – Resolve:

- **Total ≥ DC**: the lock opens, the trap is disarmed, the object is lifted.
- **Total < DC**: failure. The DM may decide that a badly disarmed trap triggers. Table rule
- A 20 or a 1 on the d20 **changes nothing** on an ability check.

⚠ The **Thief** (Fast Hands) can do it as a **Bonus Action**.

SLEIGHT OF HAND (5E, 2024 RULES) – TABLES

Sleight of Hand uses in the 2024 rules:

Situation	Check and DC
Pick a padlock (without its key)	Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) **DC 15** with Thieves' Tools
Pick the lock of manacles	Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) **DC 15** with Thieves' Tools
Escape manacles (action)	Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) **DC 20**
Disarm a trap	Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) **DC 15** with Thieves' Tools
Pick pockets	Dexterity (Sleight of Hand), DC set by the DM
Thief, level 3 (Fast Hands)	Sleight of Hand as a **Bonus Action**: pick, disarm, pick pockets

When one use case leads to another:

First check	Consequence	Next use case
Pick a padlock	Success: it opens	Access to the room or chest
Disarm a trap (failure)	The trap triggers (DM's call)	Attack roll or save (Traps sheet)
Escape manacles (DC 20)	Success: free	End of the Restrained condition and attack Disadvantage
Pick pockets (success)	The object changes hands	The owner may notice (Search)
Hide, then Sleight of Hand	Invisible, acting unseen	Ends if you attack (Stealth sheet)

Chain example: Brann picks a prisoner's manacles (DC 15, 17: success). Freed, the prisoner is no longer Restrained and can run. Had Brann failed on the cell's trap, the pressure plate would have triggered a trapdoor.

Ability + skill combinations: Table rule

*The DM decides the ability by the situation and applies proficiency if it fits. These combinations are **exceptions announced before the roll**.*

Combination	Use in play
Intelligence (Sleight of Hand)	Manipulate a geometric puzzle or disarm a logic trap.
Dexterity (Investigation)	Carefully search an area full of sensitive traps without setting any off.
Charisma (Sleight of Hand)	Misdirect the victim with patter during the trick.
Wisdom (Sleight of Hand)	Feel a lock's pins by touch, or the exact moment to slip a hand in.
Constitution (Sleight of Hand)	Sustain a delicate manipulation for hours without trembling.
Strength (Sleight of Hand)	Force a mechanism with controlled pressure (bend a bar without a sound).

Neighboring skills:

Skill	Use in play
Dexterity (Stealth)	Steal without being seen: position first, then act.

How to choose: Table rule

1. What does the task demand: **power, agility, endurance, mind, presence**? That gives the ability.
2. Which skill describes the **know-how**? Apply proficiency if it fits.
3. The DM **announces** the combination and the DC before the roll.

*Example: Mira (Intelligence +3, Sleight of Hand proficiency +2) manipulates a mechanical puzzle, DC 15. She rolls 11 + 3 + 2 = 16: success. See also the **Athletics** sheet.*

Common table questions.

Do I need Thieves' Tools?

To pick or disarm: yes, with **Thieves' Tools**. To pick pockets or conceal an object: no.

Does proficiency in both tool and skill give a bonus?

Yes: being proficient in both the tool and the skill gives **Advantage**.

Can I pick pockets unseen?

No official DC: the DM sets it. Table suggestion: contest the roll against the target's passive Perception.

Table rule

Sleight of Hand or Stealth?

Stealth: not being seen or heard. **Sleight of Hand**: manipulating or lifting. Stealing often combines both.

What if I fail a pick?

The rules don't say: the DM decides (lost time, noise, an alert), and may make a failed trap trigger. Table rule

How does the Thief work?

At level 3, **Fast Hands**: Sleight of Hand (pick, disarm, pick pockets) as a Bonus Action.

Is a 20 an automatic success?

No: on an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect.

Which features help?

The Rogue's **Expertise**, the Rogue treating a 9 or lower as a 10, and the **Help** action (Advantage).

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

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